

Local Warming

A climate change initiative revives the tradition of communal stoves and gives women a breather



Haryana



BAKING AND BANTERING
AT A SANJHA CHULHA

By Arvind Chhabra

For most women in Punjab, dinnertime means heading to the kitchen to begin making chapatis. But things have changed in Fazilka. At dinner-time, they dress up just that little bit and are out of their homes with kneaded flour as they head for the neighbourhood *chulha*. Here, they bake their bread even as they talk and gossip before going back home with hot chapatis. The *sanjha chulha*—one of Punjab's folk traditions, said to have been started by the first Sikh guru, Guru Nanak Dev, as a community *langar*—is back. The Graduates Welfare Association, Fazilka (GWAF) that set up these tandoors may have environmental reasons behind the move, but for women these *chulhas* have come as a breath of fresh air.

"I was fed up of being confined to the house the whole day. It is so refreshing to get out of the house and meet other women," says Shama Rani, a local resident. Sandhya, apparently the youngest here, doesn't know how to use the oven but that doesn't stop her from coming here. "Bimla aunty does it for me. And if she is

not here, someone else does it. It looks easy but I have just never used it earlier. But I will learn soon," she says.

"With prices skyrocketing, the tandoor has come as a blessing. My LPG cylinder now lasts three months as against one earlier. It's my contribution towards the family," says the grey-haired Bimla. For Kavita, an added attraction is that she gets news of almost the entire town here. The seven *sanjha chulhas* have been strategically placed at street corners, temples or gurdwaras so that the largest number of families can use them. Some do it once a day, while others use it even in the afternoon. First users must light the stove.

GWAF is happy with the response to the tandoors but it had a different reason for installing these. "The world is talking about global warming and we wanted to do something about it. That is why this project was born," says GWAF's project coordinator, Lakshman Dost, 40. "We use biomass as fuel and not fossil fuels. Plus, people cook food together and their bonding increases," he adds. The taste of togetherness is back. ■